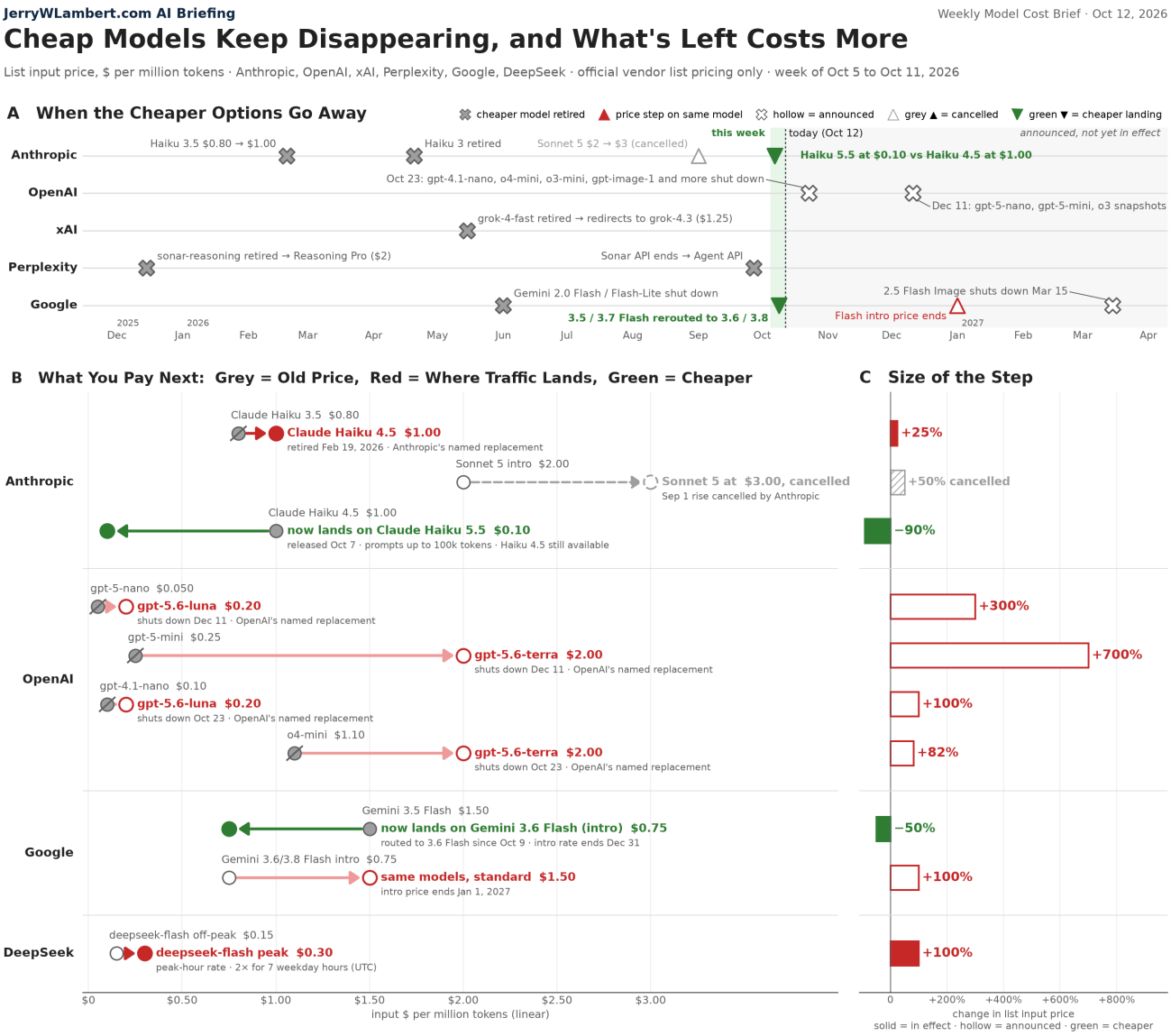
The Cheapest Claude Got Cheaper, but the Walk-Up Still Holds



Not every move goes up. On Oct 7 Anthropic released Claude Haiku 5.5 at $0.10 input / $0.50 output per million (prompts up to 100k tokens; $0.50 / $2.50 above that) vs Haiku 4.5 at $1.00 / $5, and halved Sonnet 5.5 cache hits to $0.10 per million. From Oct 9 Google routes Gemini 3.5 Flash ($1.50 / $9.00) to 3.6 Flash ($0.75 / $3.75 through Dec 31, 2026; $1.50 / $7.50 from Jan 1, 2027).

Also falling: Claude Opus 4.1 $15 → Opus 4.8 $5 · Sonnet 4.5 $3 → Sonnet 5.5 $2 (Nov 30) · gpt-5.4-nano $0.20 → gpt-6-luna $0.10 (Apr 2027). Gemini 2.5 Flash Image shutdown moved to Mar 15, 2027.
Gemini 3.7 Flash now routes to 3.8 Flash at the same $0.75 intro price. Gemini 3.6 Flash returns to $1.50 on Jan 1, 2027, the price 3.5 Flash charged. OpenAI's Oct 23 and Dec 11 shutdowns are announced, not yet in effect.
Perplexity's Sonar API ended Sep 27; on the Agent API, Sonar input fell $1 → $0.25 but output rose $1 → $2.50, so it is shown on the timeline only.
Retirements whose old list price is no longer on a vendor page (Claude Haiku 3, grok-4-fast, sonar-reasoning, Gemini 2.0 Flash / Flash-Lite) are on the timeline only. Sonnet 5's announced rise was cancelled before it took effect.
DeepSeek peak = 01–04 and 06–10 UTC weekdays. Other vendors (Z.ai, Moonshot, Mistral) omitted.

The Walk-Up

Foundation vendors keep shipping new models, and at the cheap end of each lineup the same thing keeps happening: a low-priced model is retired or repriced, and the next place that traffic can land costs more. Operators who run on "whatever is cheapest this month" get walked up a ladder of list input prices, often +25% to +700% on the successor model, while flagship and frontier prices hold flat or fall.

The mechanism is routing pressure, not a price list. A retirement does not change anyone's rate on paper. It deletes a destination. Default routes, failover routes, and every hard-coded model id that pointed at the cheap model have to go somewhere, and the vendor decides both which model goes away and which model it names as the replacement. When the named replacement lists higher, the bill goes up without a single price on the page changing.

This week pushed back on that pattern. Anthropic released a Haiku at a tenth of the old Haiku price, and Google started routing an older Flash model to a cheaper one. Both are drawn in green on the chart. The walk-up is still the default at OpenAI, xAI, Perplexity, and DeepSeek, and OpenAI's next forced moves land in 11 days. The lesson from this week is not that the pattern broke. It is that you have to price each successor on its own instead of assuming.

How to read the chart above:

- **Panel A.** One lane per priority vendor. Grey ✕ marks a cheaper model retired; red ▲ marks a price step on the same model or a forced move to a costlier successor; green ▼ marks a move that lands somewhere cheaper. Hollow markers are announced but not yet in effect; a grey triangle is a rise that was announced and then cancelled. The green band is the week of Oct 5 to Oct 11; the dashed line is Oct 12.
- **Panel B.** Linear $/M input axis. Grey dots are the old price; red dots are where traffic lands next; green dots are cheaper landings.
- **Panel C.** The same step as a percentage. Solid bars are already in effect, hollow bars are still pending, and green bars are price decreases. Retirements whose old list price is no longer posted on the vendor's own pages appear on the timeline only.

Vendors covered, in analysis priority order: **Anthropic, OpenAI, and xAI first**; then **Perplexity, Google (Gemini), and DeepSeek**. Other vendors appear only when they sharpen the same story.

What the Priority Vendors Show

Anthropic. The walk-up history is still on the chart: Haiku 3.5 retired at $0.80/M input with Haiku 4.5 at $1.00 as the named replacement (+25%, in effect since Feb 19), and a planned Sonnet 5 rise from $2 to $3 that Anthropic cancelled. On Oct 7 Anthropic broke its own ladder at the bottom. **Claude Haiku 5.5** (`claude-haiku-5-5`) launched at **$0.10 input / $0.50 output per million tokens** for prompts up to 100,000 tokens, with cache hits at $0.01. Above 100,000 tokens the whole request bills at **$0.50 / $2.50**, and Anthropic's pricing page now spells out that prompt length counts cache reads and cache writes too. Even that long-prompt rate is half of Haiku 4.5's $1.00 input. Two caveats keep the math honest. Haiku 5.5 uses Anthropic's newer tokenizer, which produces roughly 30% more tokens for the same text, so the like-for-like input saving is closer to 87% than 90%. And Haiku 5.5 is the one current Claude model where long prompts cost more; Anthropic's other recent models bill the full 1M context at one rate. Haiku 4.5 stays active at $1 / $5, with retirement "not sooner than" Oct 15, 2026 and no retirement notice yet. The same

day, Anthropic halved Sonnet 5.5 cache hits from **$0.20 to $0.10** per million; Sonnet 5.5 input and output stay at $2 / $10.

OpenAI. No standard list price changed this week, and the walk-up is on schedule. On **Oct 23, 2026**, gpt-4.1-nano shuts down with gpt-5.6-luna as the named replacement ($0.10 → $0.20, +100%), and o4-mini shuts down with gpt-5.6-terra as the named replacement ($1.10 → $2.00, +82%). The same day also retires o3-mini, gpt-3.5-turbo, gpt-4, gpt-4-turbo, gpt-4o-2024-05-13, o1, o1-pro, and gpt-image-1, among others. On **Dec 11**, the gpt-5-nano snapshot moves to gpt-5.6-luna ($0.05 → $0.20) and the gpt-5-mini snapshot to gpt-5.6-terra ($0.25 → $2.00). New this week: an **Ultrafast** service tier for gpt-6.1-sol priced at 6x Standard ($12 input / $60 output per million against $2 / $10). That one is opt-in, not a forced move, so it is not drawn on the chart.

xAI. No list price or retirement changes this week. grok-4-fast was retired May 15; calls to its model names auto-redirect to grok-4.3 and bill at grok-4.3 rates ($1.25 input / $2.50 output per million). xAI no longer posts grok-4-fast's old price, so the size of that step is not charted. grok-4.3 also doubles to $2.50 input for prompts of 200,000 tokens or more.

Perplexity. No change to Sonar or Agent API model rates. sonar-reasoning was removed on Dec 15, 2025, with sonar-reasoning-pro ($2 input / $8 output per million) as Perplexity's recommended path, and the Sonar → Agent API migration stays mixed (input down, output up, plus tool fees). One small cut this week: the Decisions API model `pplx-decider-v1-27b` fell from $0.04 to $0.02 per million input tokens, and a new `pplx-decider-v1.1-27b` lists at the same $0.02 with free output. That API is a narrow decision service, not a general chat model, so it sits in the counter-examples rather than on the chart.

Google (Gemini). The quietest move of the week was also the most structural. Google's pricing page, updated Oct 9, no longer lists **gemini-3.5-flash** or **gemini-3.7-flash**, and its deprecations page now says requests to them are automatically routed to **gemini-3.6-flash** and **gemini-3.8-flash**. No shutdown date is posted, and calls keep working. For 3.5 Flash traffic this is a step down for now: 3.5 Flash listed at $1.50 input / $9.00 output, and 3.6 Flash lists at **$0.75 / $3.75 through Dec 31, 2026**. On **Jan 1, 2027** both 3.6 and 3.8 Flash step to **$1.50 / $7.50** (+100% on input, announced). So rerouted 3.5 Flash traffic ends up back at its old input price and a lower output price, and 3.7 Flash traffic lands at the same price on a different model. A correction to last week's brief: this week Google moved the shutdown of gemini-2.5-flash-image from Oct 2, 2026 to **Mar 15, 2027**, with gemini-3.1-flash-lite-image as the recommended replacement. Google's newest image model, `gemini-nano-banana-2.1` (released Oct 6), lists at $1.50 input, $7.50 text output, and $30 per million image-output tokens.

DeepSeek. No list or retirement changes this week. Peak-hour pricing still doubles deepseek-flash input from $0.15 to $0.30 per million during 01:00 to 04:00 and 06:00 to 10:00 UTC on weekdays, which is a time-of-day walk-up rather than a model retirement. DeepSeek's pricing page also notes that the retired `deepseek-v4-flash` names are still accepted, served by DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash, and billed at the Flash price. That is a retirement with no price step.

Counter-Examples (Keep the Claim Honest)

The walk-up is concentrated at the **cheap end**, and this week two vendors moved that end down:

- **Anthropic, Oct 7:** Haiku 4.5 at $1.00 → Haiku 5.5 at $0.10 on input ($5 → $0.50 on output) for prompts up to 100,000 tokens, about 90% cheaper on list and about 87% after the tokenizer difference. Long prompts at $0.50 / $2.50 are still half of Haiku 4.5.

- **Anthropic, Oct 7:** Sonnet 5.5 cache hits $0.20 → $0.10 per million (input and output unchanged at $2 / $10).
- **Google, from Oct 9:** Gemini 3.5 Flash ($1.50 / $9.00) now routes to 3.6 Flash ($0.75 / $3.75), −50% on input through Dec 31, 2026, flat on input from Jan 1, 2027, and lower on output either way.
- **Perplexity, this week:** Decisions API input $0.04 → $0.02 per million.
- **Still standing from earlier:** Opus 4.1 at $15 → Opus 4.8 at $5; Sonnet 4.5 at $3 → Sonnet 5.5 at $2 (from Nov 30); gpt-5.4-nano at $0.20 → gpt-6-luna at $0.10 (Apr 2027).

If you only watch frontier prices, the market looks cheaper. If you watch where high-volume "fast / mini / nano / flash" traffic is forced to land after a retirement, the ladder mostly goes up. This week Anthropic is the clearest exception, and it is a real one.

Last Week in This Frame (Oct 5 to Oct 11)

One new low-end model from a priority vendor, one price cut on an existing model, one silent reroute, and no new shutdown dates on the mainstream text models of the six. OpenAI's Oct 23 shutdowns are still pending as of Oct 12.

Anthropic. Claude Haiku 5.5 went public on Oct 7 at $0.10 / $0.50 (up to 100,000-token prompts) and $0.50 / $2.50 above that, with a 1M-token context window, 128K max output, and retirement not sooner than Oct 7, 2027. Sonnet 5.5 cache hits were halved to $0.10 the same day. Haiku 4.5 is still active with no retirement notice. Sonnet 4.5 is still set to retire Nov 30, 2026, with Sonnet 5.5 as the named replacement.

OpenAI. No standard price change. gpt-6.1-sol gained an Ultrafast tier at 6x Standard. The Oct 23 and Dec 11 shutdown lists did not change.

xAI. No material public list or retirement moves.

Perplexity. Decisions API cut to $0.02 per million input tokens, with a new v1.1 model. No Sonar or Agent API rate changes.

Google (Gemini). gemini-3.5-flash and gemini-3.7-flash came off the pricing page (dated Oct 9) and now route to 3.6 Flash and 3.8 Flash. The gemini-2.5-flash-image shutdown moved out to Mar 15, 2027. New shutdown dates landed for preview models only: Nov 17, 2026 for several text-to-speech and live-audio previews, and Oct 23, 2026 for `deep-research-pro-preview-12-2025`. The Jan 1, 2027 intro-to-standard step on 3.6 and 3.8 Flash is unchanged.

DeepSeek. No price or retirement changes; peak-hour pricing continues.

Outside the six. Mistral released Mistral Large 4 (public preview) on Oct 6 at $0.68 input / $2.09 output per million, shown as a sale price against $1.36 / $4.18 with no end date. That is an intro discount with no timer on the page, and it should be budgeted at the higher number.

What Operators Should Do With This

1. **Budget the successor before Oct 23.** gpt-4.1-nano and o4-mini traffic lands on gpt-5.6-luna ($0.20) and gpt-5.6-terra ($2.00) in 11 days. Price those rates into default and failover routes now, not after the first invoice.
2. **Test Haiku 5.5 as the low-cost Claude route before Haiku 4.5 gets a date.** Anthropic lists Haiku 4.5's retirement as not sooner than Oct 15, 2026, and has posted no notice yet. Measure cost per

task, not per token, because of the roughly 30% token increase, and watch the 100,000-token line, which counts cached tokens.

3. **Check what you are actually being served.** Google rerouted 3.5 Flash and 3.7 Flash with no shutdown date. Calls still succeed, but a different model answers them. Re-run your evals and move to the new model ids on purpose.
4. **Treat intro prices as timers.** Gemini 3.6 and 3.8 Flash step +100% on input on Jan 1, 2027. Mistral Large 4's sale price has no posted end date at all. Plan on the standard rate.
5. **Keep frontier prices and opt-in tiers separate from volume models.** Cheaper Opus and Sonnet prices and a 6x Ultrafast tier both tell you little about what nano, mini, and flash traffic will cost after the next retirement.

Prices and dates in the chart and this brief come from vendors' own pricing, model, and deprecation pages and release notes (checked each weekday from Oct 5 to Oct 12, 2026). Where a vendor no longer posts a retired model's old price, the brief gives the date and replacement but no price step. No aggregator prices.